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Swiss Red Cross



COMMUNITY HEALTH MODULE

Community
mobilization
and effective
communication



ABOUT THIS MODULE

This module is about working with communities to build trust, participation and resilience. It gives simple guidance and examples to help you to communicate well, to understand local priorities, and to encourage participation, ultimately mobilizing people around shared community goals.

By the end, you'll feel more confidence in mobilizing communities and helping them to grow stronger together.

Introduction: What is community mobilization?

Community mobilization is the process of working with communities to help them identify their own needs, strengths and priorities – and to support them in taking collective action.

It is not about telling people what to do. It is about facilitating, listening, guiding and enabling communities to organize themselves to improve their health, safety and well-being.

When communities take the lead in identifying and solving their own problems, the results are stronger, fairer and more sustainable. Volunteers play an essential role in this process, helping communities connect, plan and act in the right direction.



Why is community mobilization so important?

Community mobilization:

- Builds long-term trust between volunteers and communities
- Increases ownership and participation
- Promotes inclusion and listening to those most vulnerable
- Strengthens resilience by encouraging people to use their own capacities to face challenges
- Creates lasting partnerships between communities, local authorities and National Societies

CRITICAL

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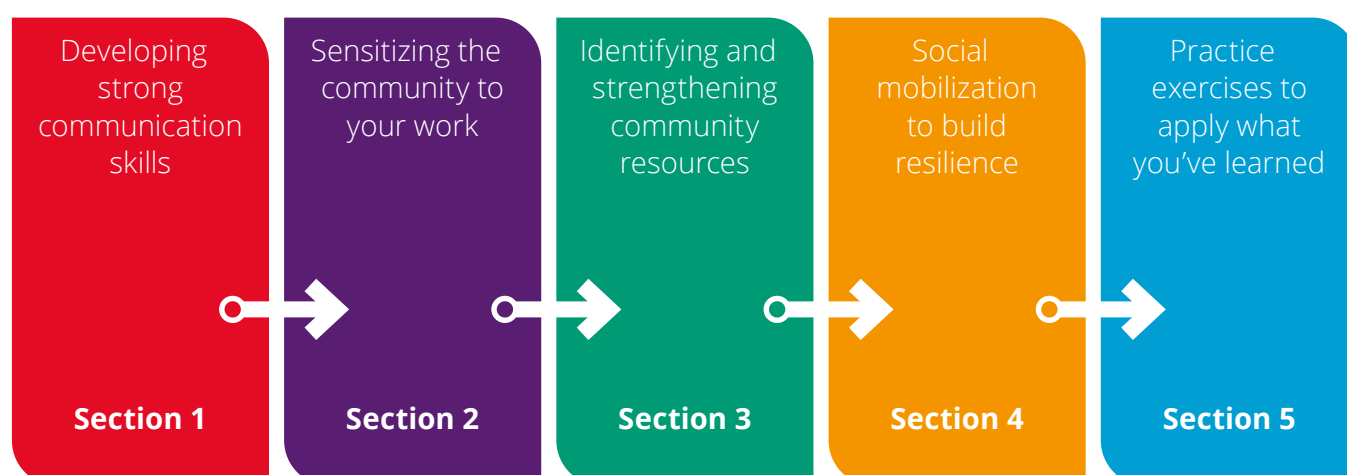
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LEARNING GUIDE FOR THIS MODULE



SECTION 1



Developing strong communication skills

WHY COMMUNICATION MATTERS?

Communication is at the heart of all volunteer and community work. Volunteers engage with people in many different settings – community meetings, household visits, health promotion and behaviour change activities, during assessment, etc. Every interaction is an opportunity to build trust, share information, and empower community members to take action.

Effective communication isn't just about speaking clearly. It's about listening, understanding and adapting your messages and approaches to the needs and context of the people with whom you are engaging. When communication is respectful, simple and two-way, it builds the foundation for cooperation and change.

Good news – communication is a skill like any other, it can be learned, practised and strengthened over time.

WHAT ARE SKILLS FOR EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION?

These practical skills will help you communicate more effectively in your work:

1. USE CLEAR, SIMPLE MESSAGES:

Avoid technical terms or jargon and avoid speaking fast.

EXAMPLE

Instead of saying “hypertension” say “high blood pressure” and explain why knowing your blood pressure matters.

Break ideas into small, manageable points. Focus on one key message at a time.

2. USE POSITIVE, OPEN BODY LANGUAGE:

Face the person, keep your posture relaxed, and match the level of the people with whom you are talking (sit if they sit, stand if they stand, etc.).

EXAMPLE

If people are sitting on the floor, sit down rather than stand over them when talking.

Developing strong communication skills

3. PRACTISE ACTIVE LISTENING

Ask questions to understand the person's needs, concerns, resources and perspectives. Give full attention, avoid interrupting, and try to summarize what the other person has communicated to you. These actions make the speaker feel heard and respected.

EXAMPLE

Summarize what you heard: "You're saying you're concerned about your child's cough, so let's talk about what you've observed."

4. ENGAGE WITH APPROPRIATE EYE CONTACT

Looking at the person you are speaking to is an important way to show attention and respect. But adapt to local norms on this – in some cultures prolonged eye contact may be seen as disrespectful.

5. SHOW RESPECT AND INTEREST

Value everyone's input and respond with empathy, even if you disagree.

EXAMPLE

"Thank you for sharing – that is an important point I didn't know."

6. USE CREATIVE METHODS TO SHARE INFORMATION

Use visuals, drawings or writings to explain points in a more engaging way. Combine information sharing with entertainment – stories, drawings, short plays, making learning more memorable.

EXAMPLE

Tell a story about a neighbour treating a small burn with the first-aid skills they learned.

TIP TO REMEMBER

- The best communicators aren't those who talk the most – they are the ones who listen and adapt to their audience.



Developing strong communication skills

COMMON COMMUNICATION BLOCKS

Even with the best intentions, communication can sometimes break down.

Barriers might include:

- Physical distance
- Lack of trust
- Conflicting opinions or misunderstandings
- Stress, anxiety or illness
- Complicated or overly formal language
- Volunteers or staff appearing “too different” or unrelatable
- Lecturing people rather than listening and adapting to what they say

Recognizing the presence of barriers early helps you to adapt and overcome them.

REDUCING COMMUNICATION BLOCKS

To overcome barriers and maintain good communication:

- Stay calm and express your views gently
- Listen actively and ask clarifying questions
- Show respect for different opinions, beliefs and feelings
- Avoid scolding, lecturing or gossiping
- Adapt your message to the situation, be flexible
- Take a break if necessary
- Practise regularly, as experience improves confidence and adaptability
- Use appropriate body language that shows respect towards others
- Wear appropriate clothing per context



TIP TO REMEMBER

The more you communicate, the more naturally it will come.

OVERCOMING LANGUAGE BARRIERS

When language differences exist, take extra care to ensure mutual understanding:

- Learn key local words, phrases and local greetings
- Use interpreters or bilingual Red Cross or Red Crescent staff, volunteers or community members
- Be aware of subtle differences in meaning when translating
- Use visual aids – pictures, gestures and demonstrations often convey more than words
- Repeat key messages in multiple ways
- Ask participants to explain messages back to ensure understanding
- Be patient – clarity is more important than speed

SECTION 2



Sensitizing the community to your work

WHY SENSITIZATION MATTERS?

Before any activity begins, communities need to understand:

- Who you are
- What you are doing
- How it benefits them
- How they can participate

Proper sensitization builds trust, transparency and ownership. When people understand your intentions from the start, they are more likely to participate, contribute ideas and feel proud of achievements.

WHAT IS A SENSITIZATION MEETING?

A sensitization meeting is an introductory session where volunteers:

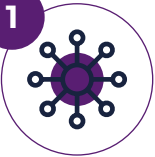
- Share information about planned activities
- Encourage community participation from the beginning
- Clarify roles and expectations

Think of this as the first step in partnership. Rather than starting activities immediately, you pause to inform, listen and co-plan with the community.

Sensitizing the community to your work

PREPARING FOR A SENSITIZATION MEETING

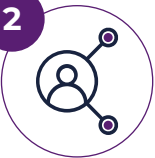
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CONNECT FIRST WITH LOCAL LEADERS AND RESPECTED FIGURES

Meet chiefs, religious leaders and other trusted individuals before holding the larger meeting. Their endorsement helps build credibility and alignment with community priorities.

2



ENGAGE OTHER RELEVANT STAKEHOLDERS IN THE COMMUNITY

Find out the respected and influential people in the community. This can include health workers, teachers, youth leaders, women's group leaders, traditional healers, etc. They can support your message, spread awareness and again help alignment of your work with community priorities.

3



ENSURE INCLUSIVITY

Make sure all groups are represented: women, men, youth, elders, people with disabilities, minority/marginalized/vulnerable groups in the community.

4



PLAN YOUR KEY MESSAGES

Keep messages short, clear, and easy to understand.

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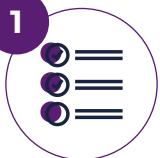


MANAGE EXPECTATIONS WITH TRANSPARENCY

Be clear about what Red Cross Red Crescent can and cannot do in this specific setting. Avoid raising hopes for resources or support that cannot be delivered.

Sensitizing the community to your work

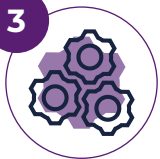
KEY POINTS TO INTRODUCE

- 

1 PURPOSE OF YOUR WORK

Explain clearly what the activity is (an assessment, an evaluation, a health activity, etc.) and how it links to community well-being.
- 

2 BENEFITS OF PARTICIPATION

Highlight how the community's involvement makes the project stronger and more sustainable.
- 

3 BUILD ON EXISTING ACTIVITIES AND ASSESSMENTS

Show that you respect what is already happening, and that your work adds to – not replaces – local efforts or works to improve the issues that have been identified by locals.
- 

4 HOW DECISIONS WILL BE MADE

Emphasize collaboration and joint planning, not outside experts deciding for the community. It is important to remember not to promise anything that cannot be provided.
- 

5 ROLE OF RED CROSS RED CRESCENT VOLUNTEERS AND COMMUNITY GROUPS

Clarify how you will work together, and what support or facilitation the Red Cross Red Crescent can provide.



TIP TO REMEMBER

After a sensitization meeting, you could ask a few participants to explain the purpose of your work back to you in their own words. This will check for understanding and highlight whether your message was clear and translated well to this community.

SECTION 3



Identifying and strengthening community resources

WHY COMMUNITY RESOURCES MATTER?

Communities already have strengths, people, skills, organizations and possible financial resources. Mobilization builds on these resources rather than only focusing on gaps.

Using familiar and trusted resources makes activities likely to be more effective, sustainable and accepted by the community.

Benefits of building on local resources:

- Strengthens ownership and sustainability
- Shows respect for local knowledge
- Builds community pride and confidence
- Reduces dependency on external help
- Supports resilience for future challenges

Examples of important community resources:

- **Community groups:** women's groups, youth clubs, sports teams, religious associations, community health committee (see explanation on next page), etc.
- **Local leaders:** political, religious, traditional, healers/health, education
- **Knowledge and skills:** teachers, health professionals, traditional healers, artisans, farmers, people with first aid or disaster response training
- **Physical spaces and events:** schools, health posts, community halls, markets, festivals, religious gatherings, etc.
- **Networks and informal support systems:** neighbours, families and social networks that already help each other in times of need



TIP TO REMEMBER

Resources should feel familiar, trusted and “of the community”, for example:

- Using a market square for a health activity is better than renting an unknown hall outside the village.
- Sharing messages through respected elders or religious leaders might be more effective than bringing in unfamiliar “expert” speakers.
- A drama performed in the local dialect will resonate more than a video in a national language people rarely use.

Identifying and strengthening community resources

WHAT IS A COMMUNITY HEALTH COMMITTEE (CHC)?

A CHC is a local group of trusted people who come together to help sustain health and mobilization efforts.

The committee can:

- Represent all the different groups in the community (women, men, youth, elders, vulnerable groups/minorities)
- Link the community and the health system
- Help plan, implement and monitor activities
- Mobilize resources people already know and trust
- Ensure vulnerable groups are included and heard
- Strengthen resilience by preparing for future crises – because people are more likely to follow guidance from trusted, local representatives

Good practice for a community health committee:

- Ensure members are familiar and respected within the community (not outsiders)
- Rotate roles to prevent domination by a few individuals
- Keep records of decisions and share them openly
- Build on familiar systems, like using existing community meeting days instead of creating new ones

Identifying and strengthening community resources

HOW TO IDENTIFY COMMUNITY RESOURCES?

Community walk/ mapping



Walk around with local leaders and members.

Identify landmarks, facilities, safe spaces and meeting places people already use.

Draw a simple map together and mark resources.

Interviews with key people or organizations



Speak with leaders, teachers, health workers, shopkeepers or households.

Ask about activities and solutions that already work locally.

Example question:

Who do people turn to for advice when there's an emergency?

Observation



Notice where people gather and who is respected.

Look for daily practices that could be used for health promotion (e.g. mothers talking at the water source, youth playing football, weekly prayer meetings).

Community discussions or focus groups



Ask groups to list resources they know and trust.

Engage women, youth and marginalized/vulnerable groups in the identification of resources.

For more methods to assess a community, see the [Community assessment module](#).

SECTION 4



Social mobilization to build resilience

WHAT IS SOCIAL MOBILIZATION?

Social mobilization is the process of bringing people together to act collectively on issues that affect their community. It builds awareness, encourages participation, and strengthens the community's ability to respond to challenges.

WHAT IS RESILIENCE?

Resilience is the ability of a community to cope, adapt and recover from challenges whether they are sudden (like disasters or disease outbreaks) or ongoing (such as poverty, food insecurity or health risks).

A resilient community doesn't just survive, it prepares, adapts, responds and grows stronger from challenges, using existing knowledge, skills and resources.

Characteristics of a resilient community:

- Meets basic needs such as food, water, shelter and healthcare
- Is socially connected, with neighbours supporting each other
- Provides opportunities for livelihoods, education and personal development
- Maintains and manages infrastructure and natural resources
- Is inclusive and fair, ensuring all community members including vulnerable groups are considered

HOW RED CROSS RED CRESCENT CAN SUPPORT RESILIENCE?

Red Cross Red Crescent staff and volunteers play a key role in helping communities become stronger and better prepared.

They can support communities to:

- Identify vulnerabilities and capacities – what challenges does the community face, and what strengths already exist?
- Facilitate cooperation and joint problem-solving – encourage groups to work together to find local solutions
- Promote healthy behaviours and preparedness – share knowledge and practical tips for disease prevention, hygiene and safety
- Strengthen links between community and health services – connect people to clinics, first aid or government support
- Ensure vulnerable voices are included – women, youth, elders, people with disabilities, minorities and vulnerable groups should all be heard

Social mobilization to build resilience

When Red Cross Red Crescent staff and volunteers use social mobilization effectively, they:

- Raise awareness about important health, safety, or preparedness issues
- Encourage equal participation from all members, including women, youth and vulnerable groups
- Build local ownership so solutions are practical, sustainable, relevant and effective
- Strengthen community networks for faster, coordinated action during future responses
- Encourage feedback mechanisms and community accountability

Practical ways volunteers can use social mobilization:

- Campaigns and advocacy, e.g. promoting vaccination, hygiene practices or safe water use
- Preparedness drills: practising community responses to floods, fires or disease outbreaks
- Resource mobilization: organizing community clean-ups, food distributions or first aid kits
- Facilitating community actions and inspiring through creativity: using drama, storytelling, songs or games to teach healthy behaviours



TIP TO REMEMBER

Social mobilization works best when it:

- Is focused on solving local problems that matter to the community and uses trusted familiar community members and resources



SECTION 5



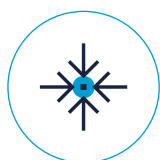
Practical group exercises

PURPOSE OF PRACTICAL EXERCISES

Training exercises help staff and volunteers apply what they've learned in real life situations, practise their skills safely, and build confidence before engaging with the community. Each activity is designed to strengthen communication, planning, community engagement and empowering.

ACTIVITIES FOR PRACTICE

1. Roleplay communication



Objective: to practise clear, respectful and culturally appropriate communication and active listening



How to do it:

- Pair up volunteers, one plays the community member, the other the volunteer
- The community member will talk about their perceptions of problems in the community, and the volunteer will practise listening and summarize the key points at the end
- Focus on active listening, body language and feedback
- Practise situations where communication blocks may occur and applying the tips for effective communication practise how you would overcome these barriers

EXAMPLE OF A COMMUNICATION BARRIER BETWEEN COMMUNITY MEMBER AND VOLUNTEER

Volunteer: "You really must wash your hands before eating and after using the toilet. That's the only way to stop disease from spreading and that's probably why you are getting sick."

Community member: "We try, but water isn't always nearby. Sometimes we save water for cooking instead."

Volunteer: (pausing, realizing they might be lecturing the person rather than listening, and adapting their communication) "I understand, that makes sense. It sounds like access to water is a problem for you."

Community member: "Yes, especially during certain times of the year."

Volunteer: "Thank you for explaining. Maybe we can talk about what could work when water is limited, like using a small container with a drip tap. Could that help?"

Practical group exercises

2. Plan a sensitization meeting



Objective: learn to prepare and organize a meeting that informs and engages the community



How to do it:

- In small groups, choose a topic (e.g. hygiene, vaccination, disaster preparedness) that is relevant in your context
- Plan the meeting: identify participants (leaders, teachers, women, youth vulnerable groups), set objectives, key messages and methods of delivery



Reflect: on engagement strategies, proposed logistics and inclusivity

3. Community mapping exercises



Objective: identify resources, networks, risks and vulnerable groups



How to do it:

- Choose either your community or a small area that is familiar to you
- Draw a simple outline map of the area, marking gathering places, skilled individuals, community groups, health facilities, water points and schools
- Also map the risks and vulnerabilities in the area
- You could try to map the power/influence of the area, who influences whom
- Discuss which resources are familiar and trusted, and how they could be used for volunteer activities

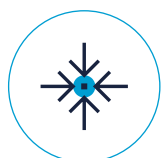
TIP TO REMEMBER



Input from different diverse groups in the community/among the volunteer peer group is essential to capture a complete and accurate picture. Example – you are not going to be aware of all the important gathering places without getting input from diverse groups.

Practical group exercises

4. Resilience and mobilization scenario



Objective: help volunteers understand vulnerabilities, capacities and actions to strengthen resilience



How to do it:

- Present a scenario (e.g. flood, fire, disease outbreak, etc.)
- In groups identify:
 - Vulnerabilities: risks or weaknesses that make the community more exposed
 - Capacities: existing strengths, resources and skills
 - Actions: what can be done to reduce risks, strengthen resilience and mobilize the community



Debrief: discuss which actions are most feasible, how they could be implemented with community participation, and how volunteers can support resilience using local resources.

Example of a scenario

Possible seasonal outbreak of dengue in the community



Vulnerabilities

- Many households store water in open containers, creating mosquito breeding sites.
- Waste is often not properly disposed of, leading to standing water and increased mosquito breeding sites.
- Some families delay seeking care due to cost, distance or mistrust of health facilities.
- The children and older adults in the community are particularly vulnerable to severe illness.
- Communication gaps, as not everyone receives timely information about prevention measures and symptoms.
- Limited awareness that dengue risk increases after the rainy season.
- Few organized community clean-up efforts or regular inspections of mosquito breeding sites.

Capacities

- Strong sense of community cooperation.
- Local health volunteers trained in health promotion, community-based surveillance and community outreach.
- Nearby clinic provides basic diagnosis and treatment for dengue and related illnesses.
- Schools and religious groups can help spread prevention messages.
- Local authorities are open to collaboration with community initiatives.
- A small community health solidarity fund exists to support families facing medical costs.

Actions to strengthen resilience and mobilize the community

- Awareness: organize regular education sessions and home visits on dengue prevention, symptom recognition and early treatment.
- Preparedness: develop a simple household checklist on water storage, waste disposal, and when to seek medical help.
- Coordination: hold a coordination meeting before the high-risk dengue season with community groups, health volunteers and local authorities to plan joint response actions.
- Mitigation: launch monthly clean-up campaigns to remove standing water and improve waste disposal.
- Protection: train volunteers to identify high-risk areas and report suspected cases early.

Community health series



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The **International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies (IFRC)** is the world's largest humanitarian network, with **191 National Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies** and around **16 million volunteers**. Our volunteers are present in communities before, during and after a crisis or disaster. We work in the most hard to reach and complex settings in the world, saving lives and promoting human dignity. We support communities to become stronger and more resilient places where people can live safe and healthy lives, and have opportunities to thrive.